

The Business Edition

CEO-Fraud Defense — Wire-Transfer Protection for Companies

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The threat: a scammer clones the CEO/CFO's voice from earnings calls, YouTube, or podcasts, then calls the bookkeeper with a spoofed caller ID: *"Urgent acquisition — wire \$84,000 to this account. Confidential, don't tell anyone."* This is the highest-value variant of voice-clone fraud, and it's growing fastest.

The 5 Business Rules

Rule 1 — No verbal wire, ever. Money moves only on a WRITTEN request via the approved channel (email/ERP system) — never on a phone call, voicemail, or voice message.

Rule 2 — The call-back. Any urgent money request triggers a mandatory call-back to the requester's KNOWN number (from your directory, not the caller ID). Even then, no verbal-only approval.

Rule 3 — Two approvers. Anything above a set threshold (e.g., \$5,000) requires a second approver — in person or via the written channel. No exceptions.

Rule 4 — The executive verification phrase. Each executive has a private phrase known only to finance staff (the corporate safe word). Anyone who can't produce it gets nothing.

Rule 5 — The 30-second rule. Any request for URGENT funds triggers a mandatory in-person or video confirmation with the requester. Urgency is the scammer's tool — make it yours.

The Annual Drill (Do This Every Year)

1. HR/finance picks a date nobody knows about.
2. They send a realistic cloned-voice request to the AP clerk: *"This is [CEO]. I need you to wire \$12,000 to this account now. Confidential."*
3. Whoever processes it without verification fails the drill. Whoever refuses gets a bonus and public recognition.
4. Review the results at the next all-hands.

A drill that costs nothing saves the six-figure loss you can't afford.

The 5-Second Executive Habit

Every executive should say this — at all-hands, in onboarding, on Slack:

"I will never ask you to wire money by voice or by urgent text. If you ever receive such a request claiming to be from me — it is a scam. Hang up, and confirm with me in person."

Insurance: The Cheap Safety Net

- Ask your broker about **social engineering fraud coverage** (a.k.a. "authorized push payment" or "wire fraud" riders).
 - Typical policies cover 6-7 figures for a few thousand dollars a year — trivial next to the exposure.
 - Insurers often **REQUIRE** the controls above. Implementing them lowers premiums AND losses. Win-win.
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The 72-Hour Response (If a Wire Already Moved)

1. **Hour 0:** Bank fraud line — request wire recall IMMEDIATELY. Your bank files a Fedwire recall through the receiving bank.
 2. **Hour 1:** Preserve the voicemail/audio, caller ID, and any texts.
 3. **Hour 2:** File IC3 (ic3.gov) + local police report.
 4. **Day 1:** Notify your cyber-insurance carrier (if any) — most require prompt notice.
 5. **Day 1-3:** Escalate at the bank: fraud dept → compliance → ombudsman. Reference the IC3 number.
 6. **Then:** audit how it happened, update the rules, re-drill.
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The Bottom Line

The clone doesn't need to be perfect. It needs one moment of urgency and one employee who follows instinct instead of process. The Business Edition removes instinct from the equation: **process, not judgment, protects the money.**

If a "boss" calls asking for an urgent wire — it's a scam until proven otherwise by the written channel and a call-back. That's the rule. Post it by the AP desk.
